

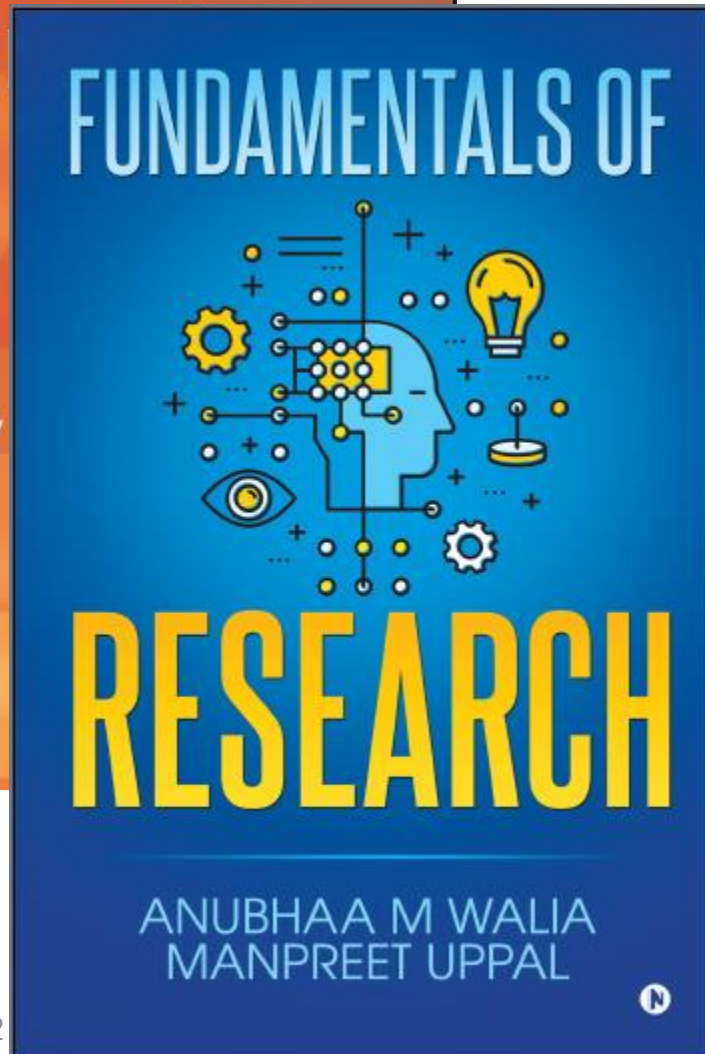
Research Fundamentals

Unit – 3: Participants and Research Ethics

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Prepared for BECE of NCIT

Contents borrowed from Dr. Ashim Khadka



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Participants

- People directly or indirectly involved in your research
 - the people you **interview**, **observe** or ask to complete a **questionnaire** or supply you with **documents**
- ethical researcher should treat participants involved in research: **fairly** and with **honesty**
- obtain **ethical clearance** before you start
- require that you consider the **ethical aspects** of your research project when you design it
- people affected by the research in any way **will not be harmed** and will be treated fairly and with dignity
 - research → ethical → approved → start
 - research → **unethical** (any part) → researcher will be asked to **think again** → **redesign** the project.

The Law and Research

- Research and behaviour throughout the project, from literature review to the final outcomes: **must be legal**
- Find out about the **law in your country** concerning such things as:
 - Data Protection Rights and Duties
 - Prize Draws and Research Participation
 - Intellectual Property Rights (IPR)
 - Technology Restrictions
 - Software Developers' Legal Liability

The Law and Research → Data Protection Rights and Duties

- Individual Rights:

- Individuals have the right to control their personal data
- Researchers must handle data responsibly, ensuring privacy and security
- Example: Suppose you're conducting a survey, you must inform participants how their data will be used and obtain their consent

- Duties of Organizations and Researchers:

- Organizations must comply with data protection laws (such as GDPR in the EU)
- Researchers should obtain informed consent, protect data, and handle it only for legitimate purposes
- Example: If you're collecting health data for medical research, ensure strict confidentiality and compliance with relevant regulations

The Law and Research→ Prize Draws and Research Participation

- Offering prize draws can encourage participation, but ethical considerations apply:
 - Clearly state the terms and conditions
 - Ensure that participation is voluntary and not force or threat
 - Avoid biasing results by attracting participants solely for prizes
 - Example: In a study on consumer preferences, you offer a gift card as an incentive, communicate that participation is optional, and the prize doesn't affect the study outcome

The Law and Research → Intellectual Property Rights (IPR)

- Legal protections for creations such as inventions, artistic works, designs, symbols, and names
 - For example,
 - Who owns the right to an image you want to use in your research,
 - Who has the copyright of your own thesis or other publications or any software you produce

The Law and Research → Technology Restrictions

- Restrictions on the kinds of technology you are allowed to use and investigate
 - Example
 - Whether your country allows unrestricted access to the Internet
 - If developing a secure messaging app, verify that encryption complies with national regulations

The Law and Research → Software Developers' Legal Liability

- The legal liability of software developers for the systems they design and create
 - Example: If you develop a medical diagnosis app, rigorous testing and proper disclaimers are crucial to avoid harm to users.

Rights of People Directly Involved

- People directly involved in your research are: -
 - Research Subjects (in Experiments)
 - Research Respondents (in Surveys)
 - Research Informants or Members (in Case Studies and Ethnography)
 - Research Participants or Co-Researchers (in Action Research)
- Rights of the people affect your research
- Participants have a **right to be treated with dignity** and, whenever possible, to **gain some benefit** from the research
- You should consider carefully whether your work is both **ethical and legal**
 - Ensure that your participants **suffer no adverse consequences** - physiological, psychological, social, political or economic etc.

Rights of Participants

- Right not to participate
- Right to withdraw
- Right to give informed consent
- Right to anonymity
- Right to confidentiality

Rights of Participants → Few Questions

- Is it ever justifiable to withhold from participants the **aims of the research**?
- Is it ever justifiable to carry out research when the subjects of the research cannot give **informed consent**?
- Is it justifiable to **use people** as the objects of research?
- Is it justifiable to carry out research that will solely or mainly **benefit the researcher** by, for example, leading to a PhD?
- Is it justifiable to carry out research when those funding the project retain the **right to censor** the findings?
- Is it justifiable to **accept funding** for health research from the tobacco industry?
- Is it justifiable to carry out research when the **findings might be used to reduce staffing levels** or **withdraw treatment** from certain categories of patients?

Responsibilities of an Ethical Researcher

- Ethical researchers can infer (conclude) their responsibilities from the rights of participants
 - Researchers should **respect participants' expectations** of anonymity and confidentiality
 - They should **not try to force** (coerce) people into participating in the research
 - They should obtain informed consent and **not deceive people** about the research
- No unnecessary **intrusion**
- Behave with **integrity**
- Follow appropriate professional **codes of conduct**
- No **plagiarism**
- Be an **ethical reviewer**

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Thank you



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